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Steve Turré

Steve Turré is an influential trombonist and has distinguished himself with Roland Kirk, Dizzy Gillespie, and as a leader with his own ensembles. He is an innovator with the use of conch shells in contemporary music.

Steve was interviewed via Zoom on November 29, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: I'm very happy to have Steve Turré with me today and my name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive. Thank you for joining me.

ST: My pleasure.

MR: I see we both dressed up for the occasion, which I'm glad to see. And that is a beautiful coat you have on, I must say.

ST: This is actually my summertime apparel but I wish it was warm instead of cold.

MR: Right. I'm fascinated by the path that notable musicians take. And I was thinking about the fact that if I'm correct, you grew up, your formative years when you might have been most affected by what you heard were in the San Francisco area?

ST: Yeah. That's right.

MR: In the mid-60s, there was so much music going on in the pop world and in the jazz world, and you were in an area known for innovations in rock music. And I wonder if there was a time when you considered that music as a career?

ST: Not as a career, no. But I enjoyed it and I played it too, but you know jazz had my heart from an early age, early age. You know my mom and dad met at a Count Basie dance. And we had big band music, that was the dance music of their day you know. So you know we had big band music in the house all the time and I used to watch the *Ed Sullivan Show* and I saw Dizzy and Bird on there, I saw Louis Armstrong many times, as well as all the other great R&B and pop acts too. So I enjoyed all kinds of music. They had Nat Cole's show and all that, so I saw all that stuff coming up in the late 50s. And then in the 60s you know I would start playing trombone in the fourth grade. And then in middle school, which was sixth, seventh, eighth, they had a jazz band and that's when I started playing jazz. And this was before I started hearing pop and rock and funk. And then in high school, well actually I'm going to go back a bit. When I first started playing trombone in the fourth grade my parents took me to the Oakland Auditorium to see Duke Ellington. Not a ghost band, the real Duke Ellington. And Coleman Hawkins was the guest soloist, Ella Fitzgerald was a guest vocalist, Clark Terry was in the band, Johnny Hodges, Britt Woodman was playing lead trombone. He took Lawrence Brown's place

So hearing that just blew my mind you know. I didn't know what they were doing but it went boing — you know something big. And so it had my heart, from that age. But then in high school I heard James Brown and I used to have a little crystal radio set. I don't know if you know what that is, but you —

MR: I do indeed. Yes.

ST: Well then you know you don't have batteries, we had a wire strung between two trees in the backyard and I had these little earphones. And I've always been a night person. So I'd lay in bed and listen, I'd just turn this little dial of whatever station would come up. I'd listen to all kinds of music, you know, Gospel music, like black Gospel music, and jazz and blues and country music you know like the Appalachian kind. What's the name for that?

MR: Well yeah, Appalachian music, Americana.

ST: Yeah, bluegrass though, I mean some of them fiddle players and guitar players playing, you know?

MR: You're right. I remember Ed Shaughnessy talking about that, he said that stuff swings also.

ST: Yeah, I used to watch *Hee Haw* sometimes. And they had a guitar player on there and a fiddle player that was mean. And you know then I heard the Beatles in person in San Francisco.

MR: You were at the last Beatles concert?

ST: Not the last. One of the first waves.

MR: One of the first waves.

ST: '64 I think it was or something like that. I heard them and I heard Jimi Hendrix live. And I used to play electric bass in a band and we'd do this in high school. I played trombone at school in the jazz band and all that, but outside of school I played electric bass and we played funk and rock and we had our own little songs we wrote. You know we played some James Brown and one or two Beatles tunes, but you know whatever tunes — and we used to play for the school dances around the area.

MR: Do you recall, your father was Italian and your mother was Mexican, is that correct?

ST: You did your homework there I see, yes.

MR: Well there's a strong musical culture from both of those populations, and I wonder if it had any effect in your home?

ST: Well my dad didn't play music but he played the hi fi. Every day he was always listening to music you know. Big band music, especially like Frank Sinatra. And he liked Tony Bennett too, Ella, Louis Armstrong he used to listen to Louis Armstrong. He never got into Bird and the bebop thing. That was the generation after him. But my mom played

flamenco and traditional Mexican dance, and she ended up playing castanets on one of my records you know.

MR: That's terrific. Can you recall the first time that you became aware of what improvisation was and the possibilities that you might be able to do it?

ST: I just took a knack to it right away. I didn't think about all that. I just did it. And in middle school I was playing in a pit band for a ball game, and it was like a little combo. We kind of played New Orleans style. We played "The Saints Go Marching In," and that kind of, "Muskrat Ramble," "Bourbon Street Parade," "Tin Roof Blues," those were some of the songs we played. So I actually started improvising in the tailgate style, the New Orleans style, before — then in high school somebody gave me a J.J. Johnson record and it was all over, man. I didn't even know you could play a trombone like that. Because at the time there weren't any recordings of notable orchestral trombone soloists. There was no — nowadays we've got Christian Lindberg, Joe Alessi and others too that are really virtuosos. But at that time there wasn't nobody playing trombone like J.J. He was on par with the best of the classical players around that league. But J.J., I said, oh man, that's where it's at. So I started to get into that music. And then a little later, once I graduated from high school I got into Coltrane. J.J. was Bird's trombone player. Curtis Fuller was Coltrane's trombone player. That's saying something.

MR: It is, and as a matter of fact on the way to school this morning I heard a Coltrane recording of "Lazy Bird" and I was speculating that that was Curtis Fuller. I suspect it was.

ST: Sure, that's off the "Blue Trane" record.

MR: Right. That facility sometimes still amazes me that a trombone can do such a thing.

ST: Well Curtis totally got to play his scales and start slow and get them to flow. It's got to be, you know, about tension liquid thing.

MR: The fact that you played a melodic instrument plus you played the bass, I would think that that gave you an added perspective on how music worked, and you're hearing the, providing the bass notes and hearing the chords on top of it. I'm not sure there's a question here except that I think the bass is so important to all the music we play and improvisation also — being able to hear the low end.

ST: Well you know in New Orleans traditional music the trombone is like a quasi-bass at times. And you know you touch on the bass and then you go up and do some other stuff, but it's connected. And of course you know you don't have a chord without a root, you know, but then you know as my ears have developed you can take a chord and move the root around. And the colors change but it's still the same chord. You know I'll tell you something I played with Dizzy, McCoy Tyner, Woody Shaw, Cedar, all the — we never,

B flat scale but you're starting on an E or E flat or whatever. It's just, that's the color. That's the tonality. By moving the root you change the color. But you know, for instance, I was asking McCoy Tyner what he played on the — mostly they call it the altered chord. Altered how? What does altered mean? It's the raise 5, raise 9. That's what they mean. Plus 5, plus 9. You know a lot of McCoy's music has that in there. And you know I could approximate the sound but there was something I was missing. And I asked him, I said, "What do you play on that chord?" And he said, "Well it's a minor major seventh." Let's say if you got a C 7 raise 9, raise 5. You play E flat minor major seventh scale. That's all it is. It's simple. You don't have to trouble your brain thinking about a flat 9 or a plus 9. It's a D flat minor major seventh scale. Once you become fluent with that, against that root, you hear it and you just play it. You don't think about it.

MR: You preceded one of my questions which I think is terrific, and the thought process and how much jazz pedagogy can be in your head now, and how much it actually helps. So a big part of your life has been teaching. Is part of what you think your task is is to make things as simple for your students as possible?

ST: Well actually if you — it's a perception. If you can perceive the simplicity, that's where it's at. If you take Charlie Parker, who I haven't heard anybody in jazz surpass that. If you break down each little fragment of his stuff it's something simple, but the way he puts that all together is profound. You know. And I tell my students, "Can you play a B major scale?" [Nods head] "Can you play a G major scale?" [Nods yes] "Can you play E flat major scale?" Um hum. I say then you can play "Giant Steps" because "Giant Steps" isn't nothing but three scales. You've got to learn to sequence them but that's all it is. You've got to sequence those colors. I think more in terms of sound and color than I do notes, and of course I always put rhythm first. Rhythm is the most important thing and that's what's lacking in most students.

MR: How do you have them work on that? To get more rhythm in their playing?

ST: Well look it. Let's make an analogy here. If you're studying harmony you've got to start with the root. And once you have three notes you have a chord and then you build off the top of that. But you go back to the root. So it's the same thing with rhythm. Let's go to the root. What makes jazz music different than — you see in academia especially in the United States but in Europe too they teach music, even jazz music, they teach it from a European perspective. And yes most of the instruments are European instruments that have been co-opted because African-Americans weren't allowed to play their instruments and we used the notation and the harmonic system of European music and it's not — I'm not putting it down, it's a beautiful thing, it's a melding of concepts. But rhythm is still the thing that we use in the harmony and the notation instruments in European music. The

response, rhythm is number one. Rhythm. And so you know if I have a student that really has a problem with rhythm I have them pick up some percussion instruments. Learn to play the clave, learn to play a basic rhythm and hold it steady. You've got to listen and make it fit like this with the other rhythms. And it breathes. It's not a metronome like a drum machine. You have to adjust to the ebb and flow of the collective. It's a collective consciousness. And I put on traditional African drummers and show them where swing comes from, because African six it's the same thing as swing, if it's played right. And when I played with Art Blakey and Max Roach, you know, the same thing — the swing feels the same as African six.

MR: Wow that's great. Did you have a conversation with your parents about the time, before you transitioned to North Texas that music is going to be my career. Was it that sort of cut and dried?

ST: You know I got off track. I started talking and wandered a little bit. I told you I was playing in a pep band in middle school. One of those times we played for a ball game and I was taking a solo. And something in my mind just told me this is what to do, and I knew it then. I didn't know how or why, I just knew I wanted to do it, and I wasn't doing it to be famous or get the girls or get rich or be on social media or, you know, get over. I was doing it because I loved it and it just made me click.

MR: Do you pass that on to your students? Or try to?

ST: If I think it's going to make a difference. You know I've found that sometimes if you give a student that's not ready too much you can blow their head and they miss the whole point and get off track in terms of what music is really about. If you look at history, Monk, and look at reality, we live on a musical planet. We're not the only beings on this planet that make music. Birds sing. Frogs sing. Insects make rhythms and they sing. Dolphins and whales sing. All over there's musical sounds being made by other creatures. And before written music, before we had MTV and music was about making money, getting over and being famous and wearing something to make people look rather than listen, music was a cultural thing in all the different cultures they had their own music as a means of communication and it's a collective thing. You have the musicians that make the music, then you have people that listen but they participate. There's no difference between music and dance and singing. It's all connected. It's all an expression of community and consciousness. And that still prevails in traditional African music. America has become about the money. You know to me, you know, I know it's a reality and you deal with it 'cause you've got to pay your bills, but to me I find it kind of offensive actually, because that's not what music's about for me.

MR: So music for you, does it have a spiritual connection of a sort?

ST: More than of a sort, it goes back to the essence of life. It's a reflection of that. Whatever the life condition is it comes out in your music. You can't fake that. You know we've all heard young students say — they've got a saxophone and they've got great fingers and they can run all the scales. I haven't really heard any of them could play "Giant Steps" through the keys. But there's probably a few. But they're not playing any music. It sounds like they're playing the computer or something. It sounds like a computer playing back of when you put a score in there and it plays it back for you, it's something, it's just mechanical. I don't feel the spirit. But when you learn to play music as a sound it touches you in a different way. I know if I learn a song by ear I retain it much better than if I read it, if I learn a song by reading. Reading definitely has a place, like for instance, you can't have a big band 'cause there's not enough time to teach everybody their part by rote. You know that's some time. But I know I played with Dizzy and he would show me some tunes just at the sound check or in the dressing room, and you've got to be able to pick them up quick, you know, but he learned it as a sound not from here but from here. The music came into your consciousness through your ears, not through your eyes. The music, when we listen to music it comes through our ears, so to me it's a big difference there. So I know when I teach I always try to teach somebody something by rote and see how quick they can pick it up, and then they struggle with it, then I'll give them the music.

MR: Okay. Was there a particular artist, you mentioned John Coltrane a little bit ago, and I wonder if there was a particular artist that you started listening to that was an on-spot example of what you're talking about with the spirit, not just the technique and the instrumental prowess, but the spirit behind it?

ST: I'll give you a good example. My first big boss that took me around the world, Ray Charles, he had nothing but soul, nothing but soul there. No matter what he plays. He plays all kinds of music. A direct connection. Rahsaan Roland Kirk is another one. Rahsaan I first played with when I was 18 in San Francisco, before I left the Bay area, when he was in town I would play with him.

MR: I'm wondering what was going through your head on the way home after that performance with Rahsaan Roland Kirk?

ST: I was still hearing the music in my head after it was over. And I was excited as all get out and that reaffirmed to me that this is what I wanted to do.

MR: Because I saw him when I was about 18 and I remember being completely overwhelmed with, I don't have to tell you what — it's like oh my God it's like a force of nature.

ST: He's a spirit man, ain't he?

MR: Yeah.

MR: It is interesting that he could have been — just if he played tenor sax he would have been like a major contributor to the jazz lexicon I guess is what I'm trying to say but and of course in addition he had all that other things that he did.

ST: You know what's interesting? I mean to me Rahsaan is the first grand master that I've played with and then later on, once I came to New York I played with him again up until he passed. But he could play anything. I mean musically. Spiritual things man. And he was encouraging but at the same time he would tell you like it is and sometimes it would hurt, or sometimes it was like a slap, a wake-up. You know? Listen. All that counts. Because I remember he played the whole history of the music in the course of the night if the music went there. And he wasn't imitating Sidney Bechet's licks or whoever's licks. He was being himself within the style of that music. You know, he was self taught. He didn't go to school. If he had a gone to school they would have told him you can't play three saxophones at once, it would have never happened. The stuff he was doing with flute man a flute teacher would have a fit. You know. So, but it's beautiful music. And we would rehearse and get to the gigs and sometimes he wouldn't even play what we rehearsed and he'd just start playing and we'd have to listen and go with it. And of course rehearsing with him wasn't by a piece of paper because he is blind. You just have to listen and learn. All that stuff made a big difference in my conception and perception of the music. I remember one time, you know, I knew something about New Orleans music. And I knew something about bebop because I was into J.J. So Kid Ory and J.J. But I missed the stuff that came in between. And so one time we were playing at a club called the Both/And in San Francisco. And he played an Ellington tune I think. Maybe "Satin Doll," I can't remember, it was '68 or something, it was a long time ago. But he played then I played, the piano was taking a solo and he tells me, right on the stage, I mean he didn't shout out it but he said, "Man, don't be playing no J.J. Johnson, this is Duke Ellington." And so I just said okay. And then afterwards we were in the dressing room and I asked him, I said, "What did you mean?" He said, "Well it's a different phrase, it's a different vernacular, it's a different language. It's connected through the blues, it's still an extension of language, but the phrasing is a little different. You know, and he took me to his hotel room and he had one of them little portable record players and he used to carry two suitcases, one had records and a little player and the other one was clothes and stuff. And, oh you'd die, he had a duffel bag, like a big military duffel bag and he'd put his saxophones in.

MR: It's funny you mention that because I recall watching, that time I saw him, he sort of made me nervous with his horns. I'm a saxophone player too, so you know he was surrounded by his instruments and of course he was blind, so he'd be reaching all over.

And I felt like I wanted to go up and help him. Odd feeling. So he had his horns in a duffel bag, huh?

ST: Yeah. And he could fix them. He knew how to fix them and stuff. Rubber bands if the springs weren't right he'd put rubber bands on them and all kinds of stuff you know. And masking tape. He had all kinds of stuff he'd do but he made it work. So you know, so he took me up to his hotel room. And he put on some records like Vic Dickinson and Trummy Young and people in between New Orleans and Lawrence Brown, people in between J.J. and New Orleans. And then I said, "Oh yeah, I like that, I like that. "But J.J." he said, "J.J. nothing. You try to play this. Get the record and try to play this." I went and got the record and tried to play what Vic Dickinson was playing on "In a Sentimental Mood" and I couldn't do it. Because he was using the slide but it wasn't slop. A lot of trombone players slide around the notes. But I can tell by listening and then knowing the history of the music that it's slop. That they're doing it because they can't really do it clean so they make that part of the thing. But when Vic Dickinson does it it's deliberate and it's expressive and it's accurate and in tune and it makes total music sense. And there's this recording of Vic Dickinson playing "In a Sentimental Mood" on a Sidney Bechet record. It's a live recording. Amazing. And that really woke me up and I realized what Rahsaan told me. He said, "As far back as you can go will directly determine how far forward you can go." If you don't have a good root the tree doesn't grow strong and bear fruit.

MR: Did he play a role in your exploration of the conch shell?

ST: Yeah. Because he introduced me to it in person. I'd seen a few people in the movies go woooh, you know. But he had a shell. He had all kinds of things that he made sounds with you know. And he had a shell and he had it down at the side and the saxophones were on the stand and all that. Three nights went by and he didn't play it and it was just sitting there. And I said, I said, "Rahsaan, the shell there, are you going to play that?" And he said, "I'll play it when the time is right." Okay. Sure. As fate would have it, the next night, you know we're in the club. Anybody can walk in the club, it's open to the public. You get all kinds of crazy people. Well this couple came in and sat right in the front table, right in front of the bandstand and proceeded to get drunk as can be, talking loud, oblivious to the music, it was rude. And you know Rahsaan kept playing. Then he wanted to play a ballad. It was a quiet thing. And they're just talking loud, and the woman said, "Man I told you to take out the garbage." And the guy said, "I did." She said, "No you didn't, you left it by the side of the car there." And they're going back and forth and so Rahsaan gets out the shell. Now Rahsaan is the kind of circular breathing and that whole publicity stunt with Kenny G, you know and I know that was a farce, and

blown him away. But anyway Rahsaan took the shell and, with circular breathing [vocalizes], but he yelled it for like five minutes, which is a long time you know. And these people, they finally realized something was going on, this sound. And they stopped talking and went [gasps] and when they did that everybody in the club goes yaaay. You know. And then there was silence. Then there was silence and Rahsaan went into a ballad with the tenor saxophone, real breathy like a Ben Webster kind of vibe. [scats]. You know it was beautiful man. But what the sound of the shell did was it brought peace. It brought another kind of energy to the air. It's different than a man-made brass instrument. It's not metal. It was alive once. But it is the roots of brass instruments. I was reading within the last year there was an article I read about some archaeologists found a shell instrument that was 17 thousand years old. So that's before written history. Before people were playing instruments. I use the same embouchure.

MR: It's fascinating — go ahead.

ST: Rahsaan just played the one note and I loved it. So I said after the gig was over and we were packing up, I said, "Man could I try that?" And he said, "Yeah, go ahead." And I blew on it and I said, "Oh man, I've got to get one of these." So my mom was going on vacation a couple of months later. She went to Hawaii. And I asked her, "If you see a shell instrument pick one up for me." And she did. And I still play it to this day. And that was 1970 I got my first shell.

MR: That's terrific. That's a wonderful story. And I watched a concert you did, I believe it was in Vienna. And you had — not only were you playing a shell but your had your brass section. And from an arranging standpoint it must be a different kind of challenge to have this group of shells and find four or five that have a range that are not only playable but that can be manipulated into whatever your compositional ideas area. Is that a fair statement? Because there was one thing you did that was like a 12-bar blues. And the conch shells are going [scats] these great licks. But how do you deal with the various pitches that they make because of the physics of the thing?

ST: Well every shell has a range. And most of them have about a fourth. You have your primary tone, and then you put your hand in it and it lowers the pitch. Kind of like a French horn you know. And so if you have a fourth to work with [scats] that's six half-steps. So you've got a smaller shell is higher pitch and a bigger shell is lower pitch. You've got a lot of notes you can work with. And if you move a half step in any direction you're going to be in the court. So you just figure it out you know, you work with what you have.

MR: There was one time during that piece where you were playing a smaller shell and a unison melody with one of your players, it had a very large shell. I don't have the word

for it, that 12-bar blues is such a versatile musical form and to hear it played with four shells was just outstanding.

ST: It's the roots of jazz. You know the way I came up, and unfortunately a lot of the young players not only can't play the blues they don't want to play the blues. That really bothers me, because that's the root of the music. The more you have an understanding of the blues the more you can express whatever you do. Because the blues come from here, not from here. It's not mathematic.

MR: Well you've played with a long list of now-famous and respected musicians, some of them were already famous when you started with them. So I'm trying to form a question about, have these people like Ray Charles and Dizzy and Rahsaan, is there one basic quality that they all have that have made them so important in jazz history?

ST: Well first of all they could all play the blues like deep, not just superficial. Not the [air quotes] blues scale, which is actually, the way I teach, that's wrong. The blues scale [scats] you know that's corny. You leave the flat fifth out. The blues is the pentatonic scale, the African scale. The flatted fifth is a passing note either going up or down. Like [scats] you'd move up. Or [scats] it moved down. But it's not a primary tone. The primary tones are the pentatonic. "Sonny Moon for Two" pentatonic scale [scats]. You know that's the blues. You've got to deal with them five notes and make music. Then, once you can get something working with those five notes then you can put in the flatted fifth and the sixth and the fourth [scats]. That's using the fourth as a passing tone coming down to the third you know. But the essence is the pentatonic. In the key of F you could say F minor pentatonic or the A flat pentatonic, you know, that's all a matter of what you want to call it, or the sound of the notes, it's a color. Those notes are special. Five fingers. Five notes.

MR: What kind of life lessons did you learn along the way from Ray Charles or Rahsaan or Dizzy? Something beyond the music?

ST: Well it's all connected. It's all connected. If you've going to really play this music you've got to live the music. And you always put the music first. People that are entertainers — well a musician is an entertainer of sorts — but there's a deeper quality to it as well. It's not just the comedian or an actor or a fashion show. It's a sound. And you're there to make a sound. That sound should be the focus of your presentation and it's what you're sharing, whatever it is that you can make the sound do, you're sharing that with your audience you see? I'm going to tell you a story. I used to work with Hugh Masekela. And you know we were playing this song and it was a very similar rhythm to the cha-cha. And you know he was from South Africa. And so I had some clave, because I play Latin music a lot. I started playing the clave and he looked at me smiling, and I

no cha-cha" and he named some African name that I couldn't pronounce to you now, I don't remember. He said blah-blah-blah. That's a rhythm from Mozambique. I said, "Yes, sir, okay." Because that's where it comes from, you see? That's where it comes from. So you know all this music, all the African people that were brought here against their will not only came to North America, they went to the Caribbean, to South America, and depending on who their colonizers were the music evolved differently. In Portugal you have the samba, bossa nova; in the Caribbean you have Afro-Cuban and soca and calypso and merengue and cumbia, plena, and bomba and so many forms. And then in America we have the blues which evolved into jazz. Blues is the root. And in America it evolved differently because the English were scared of the rhythm. They took the drum away. In Latin America they didn't take the drum away. On Sunday, when the other people went to church they were allowed to play the drum to keep some semblance of the culture. So the music evolved differently because of that. And in America it evolved a unique way because you know if you know anything about traditional African drum ensemble, they had the iron bells and they had the higher pitched drum, the djembe, and then they have lower pitched drums, the dundun, and some even have bigger bass drums. And all those different elements were put into a drumset. The cymbal became the bell, the tom-tom and snare is a djembe, the high voice. And so one person is doing what was many people. And you know it evolved differently because of that. Can you imagine if black people were allowed to have copyrights the man who invented the drumset, they'd be a billionaire by now.

MR: Indeed.

ST: So all those kind of things are relevant to the music. The music is an expression of all of that.

MR: I feel like I'm getting a terrific lesson here today, Steve.

ST: You asked, I'm telling you my experiences, you know?

MR: Yes indeed. So as your career went on you found ways not only to have meaningful musical experiences but to make a living. And you did a good amount of studio work. Can you take us through a typical day of a studio musician from getting a phone call to showing up and how that worked and what it required?

ST: Well I'll set the record straight here. What most people think of as a studio musician would be like somebody that does jingles and does movie scores and goes in and sight reads parts for background horn parts for a record date for a pop singer or whoever, something like that. I never was into that scene. Never. I might have done about what you can count on one hand that kind of work. But I did a lot of jazz record dates, which is a totally different experience. Totally different. It's not about whether you could sight read,

homework, you learn it, you have a rehearsal, and then you go in the studio and you play. You've got to listen and not just listen for what, you know, the click track or you know that kind of thing. You listen to each other in an organic way. You respond to the moment.

MR: Do you feel you play, well I'm going to rephrase my question. Do you enjoy listening to the recordings, either your own or the recordings that you're on as a sideman?

ST: Some of them. Some of them I don't, but I always feel like man I don't want to hear that. I hear my flaws and I know what my strengths and weaknesses are. We all have them. You know naturally when I don't hear something come out the way I'd like it to it bothers me. So I don't usually listen to myself you know. But there are a few records and a few cuts on various records that I say okay, I can live with that.

MR: You sound like a modest man as far as how you think about your own playing. And if you could set that modesty aside for a moment, where do you think you fall in the list of influential trombone players?

ST: It's not for me to say. Everybody has a different take. You know I mean there are some people that think Tommy Dorsey was the greatest ever and as a balladeer for that style of playing that he kind of evolved from listening to Lawrence Brown. He's got Lawrence Brown. Because Lawrence Brown used many types of vibrato. Sometimes he'd use a lip vibrato, sometimes he'd use a slide vibrato. And they used to run up to the Cotton Club to see Duke and all that and caught that ball and ran with it and made it his whole thing. And he perfected it. He was smooth as silk. And he wasn't on a mic either. All the guys that played that way in recent years, they play real soft and the put the mic right in the bell of the horn. Tommy — I've got video of Tommy man, he's three feet from the mic and you can hear the sound full, it's just singing over the band. But anyway, he wasn't a real improviser. Not really you know. He was okay but that wasn't his forte. His forte was ballads. But everybody got a different take on it. Then some people like Kid Ory, I love them all. Some people like, you know, Lawrence Brown, or they might like J.J. or Curtis or Julian Priester or Frank Rossolino. I love them all. You know they're all doing something different. They're all unique. So you know I've got a unique thing that I do and I have my influences and we're all coming out of something before us for the most part. But I use wider intervals. I started using fourths and fifths to make lines. And I got that from Woody Shaw. He showed me how to do that. So I create melodies and lines out of wider intervals. I also did a thing, I was the first to do this sound on the trombone where I use alternate positions [scats] because I was listening to Lester Young and he used alternate fingerings on the same note [scats] you know so I go [scats] and I was trying to do that but it didn't come out quite the same but it had a sound so I took that ball

going back to 1970. And of course the shells. I brought that to jazz [inaudible]. People can judge it how they want. That's not my care. I don't really care, it's not why I'm doing it.

MR: Well I'd like to go back to that for just a second. You've already explained it, but it's so important that you have that focus of why am I doing this and often times I've read sociologists and critics who seem to say that musical styles change because of the surroundings that are going on at the time. And I sometimes feel that it doesn't give enough credit to the musician who is so invested in the music that they are creating these styles because of something that's inside them.

ST: I think it's a combination of both things. Because when you look at the world today, totally different than say when Charlie Parker was around or Duke Ellington was around, much less Louis Armstrong. I mean he started out with King Oliver when the world was really a different place. They didn't even have telephones and you know, not in the households. So they just started to take that stuff on. You know, now we've got social media, you know, people when I went to the airport today, checking in you know, and then they go and show them practicing at home and all that kind of stuff. That's not what the music's about. That's all because they want to be noticed and get over and look at me. But that's not why you should play music. It's not about getting attention. Not the way I'm — you know you do it because you love it, because it's something in you that you've got to do. You know and sometimes that's a real challenge, because you don't play these instruments, sometimes it can be a challenge. Sometimes they [inaudible]. I remember, in my early years, the trombone is a particularly challenging instrument to articulate on, especially the play jazz. I remember when J.J., I was trying to figure out how to play that way. Sometimes man, I was frustrated. I hated it. The horn was frustrating. I said why didn't I pick another instrument. I loved the sound of the horn so hey, I had to figure it out and stick with it. And I never had teachers early on that really showed me proper technique. They taught me how to read, taught me about articulation to a certain degree, they didn't teach me about breath control or correct embouchure. I had to go get that much later after I was already working professionally. So it was a real challenge to be trying to change up physical aspects and perform at the same time to pay your bills you know. But you really had to be vigilant. But I'll tell you though, I practice more now that I'm older than I did when I'm younger, just to maintain. You don't see Usain Bolt running the 100-meter race anymore, do you? And he's only 30.

MR: I should ask you about *Saturday Night Live* a little bit. I've wondered, with all that talent that's been in and out of that band, when a singer, a pop singer comes on and sings along with pre-recorded music and the band is pretending to play — not your band — but the

ST: There's nothing to think. It's about money. That's what they're selling. It's all about money. They're selling this image. And you know I was there when Ashlee Simpson messed up and they put the wrong track on and she didn't know what was going on and ran off the stage. And you know it used to be Saturday night *Live*. [camera freeze] Or, they tried to do it live, it flopped. And the corporation, I guess NBC got big blowback from these big record companies and mega-corporations that own them, we've invested so much money in this artist and you let them flop on TV, because they couldn't do their show the way they do it live with the lip sync and all that stuff that's all smoke and mirrors. So they started allowing it. And it's just imagery and sales. It's about generating sales. It's not — back in the day they had all the pop music too but they also had Betty Carter on there, they had Miles on, they had Sun Ra on *Saturday Night Live*. They had Yo-Yo Ma. You know SNL is for young people basically. Everybody watches sometimes but, especially high school, college aged kids, it's big. If they had the Rolling Stones on there everybody'd go and watch, but Yo-Yo Ma, he's a master. People are going to watch that and say wow, that's beautiful music. But now it's all about the money. But I'll tell you it's a lot of fun. What gig can you do where if you're not playing you're laughing? Or well you're saying well this is the latest. Okay, this is what they're selling now. But you know all the guys in the band are great musicians. It's a thrill to play with them, and I feel blessed to be there. I've been there 36 years. This is my 37th season.

MR: How much rehearsal goes into one show?

ST: We get — it's all in one day. We've got to get there at like 10:00 in the morning, we never get out of there 'til 1, 1:30 after midnight. Long burn-out day. On Sunday I'm pretty much wasted.

MR: I see. When you're working on, let's say you get a song idea in your head or you're working on an ensemble arrangement of some sort, do you become obsessed with it? Like it gets in your head and no matter what you're doing you're still trying to work it out?

ST: Are you talking about composing?

MR: Yes.

ST: Well not consciously, you know, I more often than not write at the piano. And I'll be noodling around on the piano and I start hearing something. And I write it down before I forget. You know because if I don't the next day I'll come and start noodling and something else will come. But if I get an idea that goes boing — you know that's something I like, I write it down. Then I just leave the paper on the piano and maybe sometime a day later, a week later, a month later, who knows, I'll see it and let it marinate. You know keep — sometimes when I'm laying in bed either going to sleep or

about a certain pattern I'm hearing or a certain sound. And I'll go over it just mentally. You know, but I mean the way I am, I focus on one thing at a time. So if I'm trimming the hedge I'll be totally focused on that and make sure to cut the plant in the right place so that it grows. Because there's a certain way you're supposed to trim plants. Or if I'm, you know, doing a task, I focus on that. I'm not doing this and thinking about something else. Because I'm a believer, I'm not into multi-tasking. I think you don't do anything good when you do that. You do your best work when you focus on one thing at a time and you deal with that. And that's the way I prefer to do things.

MR: Well this has been a fascinating conversation and I'm very pleased that your mother and father met at a Count Basie dance.

ST: Yeah. They took me to see Basie too, the band with Thad Jones and Snooky Young and our great Benny Powell and Frank Foster, Frank Wess, and you know, Freddie Green and all those cats. It was great man.

MR: Just to wrap up, is there anything that, on the bandstand or not on the bandstand, that makes you aggravated to the point of anger? And then I'll flip that and what gives you great joy these days?

ST: What gives me joy is making people happy, make them feel better. You know I was talking about playing with Hugh Masekela, I forgot to tell you why I brought that up. He told me, he said when he was a kid he used to, in high school he used to cut school and go play with the older guys at rehearsals and stuff. And they let him play, they saw a talented young man you can come on and play. But he was a kid so he was cutting up and being silly and stuff. And after a while they said, "Okay, calm down man, you've got to focus here man, you know?" "You know we can have fun but you have a responsibility too." Of course he's a kid, and you know how kids feel about the word "responsibility." So he told me, he said, I said, "Well this is fun." He said, "Yeah that's cool but in our culture the musician is like a doctor. You're supposed to make people feel good." And you know that really went boing, that really rung a bell with me. So you know I always kind of felt that way but I didn't realize it, you know when he said that it was oh, yeah. You know that's one of the reasons, you know, that you do things. And a musician is another kind of healer you know, it's not like giving you medicine or something like a pill, spiritual food. And also what I love about music, and especially jazz music, is it brings all people together from different cultures and races and what-have-you. It brings everybody together. And that's what's happening. All this divisiveness, yilch.

MR: Yeah.

ST: You know when I was younger if one of the musicians in the band was bullshitting and not really trying to do their best, it used to aggravate me, but I get older now I've learned

either they're going to get it or they're not. And if it's my band I just don't call them anymore, but I thank them. But if it's not my band I know I'm not going to be there, it's not — I'm there to do the job and I go do the job and play the best that I can. But I've also been in bands where everybody is on a level with their focus and they're trying with their whole essence — body, mind, and spirit — to do the absolute best that they can every time they take that horn out the case or sit at the piano or whatever. And you know that's the environment I want to be in.

MR: Well that sounds like a nice coda, place to wrap up. And I just — this is interesting — five minutes before we started this interview I got a call from a local high school teacher asking me if I would do one of those adjudicating gigs you know for the high school jazz band. And this teacher happened to be a trombone player. And I said, "Guess who I'm interviewing in a few minutes?" And I told him, he goes, "Oh, oh he came to our festival in Oneida years ago and everybody loved him."

ST: Oh I remember that, it's upstate New York.

MR: Exactly.

ST: I remember that.

MR: Yeah well I just wanted you to know that you have a fan club up here.

ST: That's nice to know. Yeah, I remember that.

MR: Well good, I enjoyed this so much, I hope you keep getting boing moments.

ST: Me too.

MR: All right, I'm going to pause this and then we'll say our good-byes. Thank you very much.